INTRODUCTORY SOMMELIER COURSE AND EXAM

AND

CERTIFIED SOMMELIER THEORY EXAM

CURRICULUM GUIDE

INTRODUCTORY & CERTIFIED THEORY CURRICULUM

Subject Name: SPAIN - GALICIA

Learning Outcome Introductory Sommelier Course: After studying this section, a student will know the location, general climate, grape variety, and style of the Rías Baixas DO.

Learning Outcome Statement Certified Sommelier Exam: After studying this section, a candidate will know the soil type and the styles and grape varieties of Valdeorras DO and Ribeira Sacra DO. A Certified Sommelier will be able to recognize iconic producers and be able to recommend and sell food pairings with Rías Baixas Albariño to a guest.

	Introductory Level	Certified Sommelier Exam
Geography: Location	Northwest section of the Iberian Peninsula, also known as Green Spain. ***Be able to recognize Rías Baixas on a map.**	
Geography: Climate Categories	Maritime, humid, cooler than the rest of Spain.	Maritime on the coast, becoming more continental moving inland.
Geography: Physical Feature	**Bodies of Water:** Atlantic Ocean, Miño River (Spanish)/Minho River (Portuguese) *Rías Baixas means "low estuaries," referencing the defining feature of the zone.	Steep slopes in Ribeira Sacra
Soil: Type and/or Name		Granite
Grape Growing	High canopy trellising because of humidity	Terraced vineyards in Ribeira Sacra.
Winemaking	Made with modern technology, stainless steel tanks. Lees aging is common.	Occasional barrique (barrica) use.
Wine: White Grape Variety Names	Albariño	Godello
Wine: Red Grape Variety Names		Mencía
Classification		
Wine Law /Appellations: DOs	**Rías Baixas DO:** White Wines: Wines labeled Albariño must be 100% Albariño.	**Valdeorras DO:** White Wines: Godello Red Wines: Mencía **Ribeira Sacra DO** White Wines: Albariño, Godello, Red Wines: Mencía
Label Terms		
General Terms		
Style	Dry, crisp, aromatic white wines from the Albariño grape variety.	Dry, crisp white wines and light red wines. Fresh and neutral Godello in Valdeorras; Mencía, Godello, and Albariño in Ribeira Sacra.
Producer/Proprietary Brand		**Albariño:** Pazo Señorans, Granbazán, Lagar de Cervera
Vintage		
History & Lore		
Service of Beverage		
Food and Beverage Pairing		Due to its location, crisp acidity, and delicate flavor profile, Albariño is a classic match for simply prepared shellfish and bivalves.
BOS		

INTRODUCTORY & CERTIFIED THEORY CURRICULUM

Subject Name: SPAIN - LA RIOJA

Learning Outcome Introductory Sommelier Course: After studying this section, a student will know the general location, climate, grape varieties, styles, and label language of Rioja.

Learning Outcome Certified Sommelier Exam: After studying this section, a candidate will have a deeper knowledge of Rioja, including the subzones, specific aging requirements, iconic producers, and differences between traditional and modern styles. A Certified Sommelier will be able to recognize iconic producers and be able to sell and recommend food pairings with wines from Rioja to a guest.

	Introductory Level	Certified Sommelier Exam
Geography: Location	North Central Spain	
Geography: Climate Categories	Cantabrian Mountains, creating a rain shadow. Continental climate.	Climate varies with the subzone: Alta is continental, Alavesa is the coolest and wettest, Oriental is Mediterranean.
Geography: Physical Feature	**Mountains**: Foothills of the Cantabrian and Pyrenees Mountains. **Bodies of Water**: Ebro River	
Soil: Type and/or Name		Calcareous clay, ferrous clay, alluvial
Grape Growing		
Winemaking	Rioja is traditionally aged in American oak.	Carbonic maceration is common on Joven styles.
Wine: White Grape Variety Names	Viura	Malvasia, Garnacha Blanca
Wine: Red Grape Variety Names	**Tempranillo**, Garnacha	Mazuelo, Graciano
Wine Law / Appellation: DOCa	**La Rioja DOCa:** Dry red (tinto) wines from the Tempranillo grape variety and white (blanco) wines from the Viura grape variety.	**La Rioja DOCa Subzones:** Rioja Alta Rioja Oriental Rioja Alavesa
Wine Law / Label Terms / Classification	**Crianza, Reserva, Gran Reserva** Specific aging and quality tiers based on minimum required time (in ascending order) wine spends in oak barrel and bottle. **Knowledge of the actual time requirements is not necessary at this level.	**Viñedo Singular (Single Vineyard)** **Joven** **Know specific aging requirements for <u>Rioja Tinto</u>** **Crianza:** min 2 years, including 1 year in oak **Reserva:** min 3 years, including 1 year in oak **Gran Reserva:** min 5 years, including 2 years in oak

INTRODUCTORY & CERTIFIED THEORY CURRICULUM

Subject Name: SPAIN - LA RIOJA

	Introductory Level	Certified Sommelier Exam
General Terms		
Style	Dry red wines and dry white wines. Styles range from young and fresh to ageable.	Rioja Rosado (rosé) wines are also produced. Some modern producers are making more fruit-focused wines using French oak and avoiding the traditional labeling terms of Crianza, Reserva and Gran Reserva.
Producer/Proprietary Brand		Marqués de Riscal, Marqués de Cáceres, Finca Allende, Bodegas López de Heredia, La Rioja Alta
Vintage		Understand that, typically, Gran Reserva is only made in the best vintages.
History & Lore		Understand the relationship between Bordeaux and Rioja during phylloxera's devastation of France and its significance to winemaking and aging practices.
Service of Beverage		
Food and Beverage Pairing		Understand how oak use and amount of oxidation can affect the pairing.
Business of the Sommelier		

INTRODUCTORY & CERTIFIED THEORY CURRICULUM

Subject Name: SPAIN - CASTILLA Y LEÓN

Learning Outcome Introductory Sommelier Course: After studying this section, a student will know the major DOs within Castilla y León, the grape varieties used, and styles of wine produced.

Learning Outcome Certified Sommelier Exam: After studying this section, a candidate will have deeper knowledge of the major DOs within Castilla y León, including specific aging requirements. A Certified Sommelier will be able to recognize iconic producers and be able to sell and recommend food pairings with wines from Ribera del Duero to a guest.

	Introductory Level	Certified Sommelier Exam
Geography: Location	North Central Spain	
Geography: Climate Categories	Cantabrian Mountains, creating a rain shadow. Continental climate with extreme seasonal and diurnal shifts.	
Geography: Physical Feature	High altitude **meseta.** **Bodies of Water:** Duero River (called the Douro in Portugal)	
Soil: Type and/or Name		
Grape Growing		
Winemaking	Fresh white wines in Rueda. Red wines are made in a range of styles from early (young) consumption to age-worthy. Wines are aged in American oak and French oak.	
Wine: White Grape Variety Names	Verdejo, Sauvignon Blanc	
Wine: Red Grape Variety Names	Tempranillo	Mencía **Tempranillo synonyms:** Tinta del País, Tinta de Toro
Wine Law / Appellations: DOs	**Toro DO**	**Bierzo DO**
	Primarily red wines based on Tempranillo, often emphasizing ripeness and concentration.	Red, Mencía-based wines that can be enjoyed young or aged for a few years.
	Ribera del Duero DO	
	Primarily Tempranillo-based blends, in styles that range from fresh for early drinking to long-aged in American or French oak.	
	Rueda DO	
	Fresh white wines based on Verdejo and Sauvignon Blanc grape varieties.	
Label Terms	**Ribera del Duero** **Crianza, Reserva, Gran Reserva** Specific aging and quality tiers based on minimum required time (in ascending order) wine spends in oak barrel and bottle. **Knowledge of the actual time requirements is not necessary at this level.	**Ribera del Duero:** specific aging requirements for Crianza, Reserva, Gran Reserva (Tinto) **Crianza:** min 2 years, including 1 year in oak **Reserva:** min 3 years, including 1 year in oak **Gran Reserva:** min 5 years, including 2 years in oak

INTRODUCTORY & CERTIFIED THEORY CURRICULUM

Subject Name: SPAIN - CASTILLA Y LEÓN

	Introductory Level	Certified Sommelier Exam
General Terms		
Style	**Ribera del Duero:** For young consumption or long aging that can be in American or French oak.	
Classification		
Producer/Proprietary Brand		**Ribera del Duero:** Vega Sicilia, Pesquera, Pingus **Bierzo:** Descendientes de J. Palacios **Rueda:** Martinsancho
Vintage		
History & Lore		
Service of Beverage		
Food and Beverage Pairing		
Business of the Sommelier		

INTRODUCTORY & CERTIFIED THEORY CURRICULUM

Subject Name: SPAIN - CATALONIA / CATALUNYA

Learning Outcome Introductory Sommelier Course: After studying this section, a student will understand the general location, styles, and grape varieties of the Cava DO and Priorat DOCa.

Learning Outcome Certified Sommelier Exam: After studying this section, a candidate will have a deeper understanding of Priorat DOCa and Cava DO, including aging requirements. A Certified Sommelier will be able to recognize iconic producers and be able to sell and recommend food pairings with wines from these regions to a guest.

	Introductory Level	Certified Sommelier Exam
Geography: Location	Northeastern Spain, in the foothills of the Pyrenees. Near the Mediterranean Sea and the city of Barcelona.	
Geography: Climate Categories	**Priorat:** Hot and dry Mediterranean **Cava:** Moderate due to altitude (where most Cava is made).	**Priorat:** Significant diurnal shifts
Geography: Physical Feature	**Priorat:** Steep, terraced slopes. **Cava:** High-altitude sites in the Pyrenees.	
Soil: Type and/or Name	**Priorat: Llicorella** soil allows vines to dig deep for water.	
Grape Growing		**Priorat:** Terrain does not allow for mechanization. Use of bush vine (Gobelet) training, naturally low yields. ***Recognize a photo of bush vine/Gobelet training.*
Winemaking	**Priorat:** Modern winemaking, including the use of French oak, is common. **Cava:** Traditional Method sparkling wines. The **gyropalette** (a Spanish invention) is typically used instead of riddling by hand.	
Wine: White Grape Variety Names	**Cava:** Xarel-lo, Parellada, Macabeo	Garnacha Blanca, international varieties
Wine: Red Grape Variety Names	**Priorat:** Garnacha, Cariñena, international varieties	Pinot Noir, other international red varieties
Wine Law / Appellation: DO, DOCa	**Cava DO:** Traditional Method Sparkling, white, and rosado styles of wine based on native Spanish grape varieties listed above. **Priorat DOCa:** Primarily still, dry reds based on Garnacha, Cariñena, and international varieties.	**Penedès DO** **Cava DO:** Covers all of Spain, but the vast majority of Cava is made within the Penedès DO of Catalonia. **Cava Aging Requirements:** **Cava (Cava de Guarda):** min 9 months on lees **Reserva:** min 18 months on lees

INTRODUCTORY & CERTIFIED THEORY CURRICULUM

Subject Name: SPAIN - CATALONIA / CATALUNYA

	Introductory Level	Certified Sommelier Exam
Label Terms		
General Terms		
Style	Priorat is a powerful, intense, spicy Garnacha-based blend, often aged in French oak and blended with international varieties. The Cava DO is for traditional method sparkling wine.	
Classification		
Producer/Proprietary Brand		**Priorat:** Rene Barbier (Clos Mogador), Álvaro Palacios, Clos Erasmus, Clos Martinet, Scala Dei **Cava:** Gramona
Vintage		
History & Lore	Priorat is a modern Spanish wine, not a traditional style. It made a big impact in a short period of time and is highly respected.	The significance of the Gratallops project to the style and reputation of Priorat DOCa.
Service of Beverage		
Food and Beverage Pairing		Understand the effects of Priorat's oak use, ripeness, intensity, and alcohol level in regard to food pairing.
BOS		

CERTIFIED SOMMELIER EXAM THEORY CURRICULUM

Subject Name: SPAIN - OTHER DOs *CERTIFIED SOMMELIER EXAM ONLY*

Learning Outcome for Certified Sommelier Exam: After studying this section, a student will know the styles of wine made in selected DOs beyond the classic regions.

	País Vasco (Basque Country)	Murcia	DO Pago
Geography: Location	Atlantic coast of northern Spain	Mediterranean coast of southeast Spain	Distributed throughout Spain, concentrated in Castilla-La Mancha
Geography: Climate Categories	Moderate maritime (a.k.a. Green Spain)	Warm Mediterranean	
Geography: Physical Feature	Atlantic Ocean		
Soil: Type and/or Name			
Grape Growing		Historically, Monastrell vines were ungrafted due to the sandiness of the soil.	
Winemaking	Modern: temperature-controlled stainless steel tanks		Primarily international styles of red wine.
Wine: White Grape Variety Names	Hondarrabi Zuri		
Wine: Red Grape Variety Names	Hondarrabi Beltza	Monastrell (Mourvèdre)	International grape varieties
Wine Law /Appellations: DOs	**Bizkaiko Txakolina DO**	**Jumilla DO**	Understand the concept and definition of the DO Pago. ***It is not necessary to memorize the list of Pago producers.*
	Primarily dry white. Reds and rosés (rosados) are rare. Wines are lightly effervescent with high acidity. Meant for early consumption.	Dry red wine focused on pure Monastrell and Monastrell-based blends.	
	Arabako Txakolina DO		
	Primarily dry white. Reds and rosés (rosados) are rare. Wines are lightly effervescent with high acidity. Meant for early consumption.		
	Getariako Txakolina DO		
	Primarily dry white. Reds and rosés (rosados) are rare. Wines are lightly effervescent with high acidity. Meant for early consumption.		

CERTIFIED SOMMELIER EXAM THEORY CURRICULUM

Subject Name: SPAIN - OTHER DOs *CERTIFIED SOMMELIER EXAM ONLY*

	País Vasco (Basque Country)	Murcia	DO Pago
Label Terms			
General Terms			
Style	Primarily dry white wine. Reds and rosés (rosados) are rare. Wines are lightly effervescent with high acidity. Meant for early consumption.	Dry red wine	Primarily red wine
Classification			Understand the place of DO Pago in Spanish wine hierarchy. ***It is not important to learn any of their names at this level.*
Producer/Proprietary Brand		Juan Gil	
Vintage			
History & Lore		Avoided phylloxera until 1980s.	Vinos de Pagos was first created in 2003. There are 20 Vinos de Pagos as of 2022, serving the purpose of producer appellations outside of traditional winemaking styles.
Service of Beverage			
Food and Beverage Pairing	Txakoli whites are traditionally served with oily seafood.		
Business of the Sommelier			

INTRODUCTORY & CERTIFIED THEORY CURRICULUM

Subject Name: PORTUGAL

Learning Outcome Introductory Sommelier Course: After studying this section, a student will know the location of Portugal on a map and Portugal's important wine regions and grape varieties.

Learning Outcome Certified Sommelier Exam: After studying this section, a candidate will be able to match major grape varieties to their respective DOPs and styles. Certified Sommeliers will be able to recommend and sell food pairings with wines from Portugal to a guest.

	Introductory Level	Certified Sommelier Exam
Geography: Location	On the Iberian Peninsula on the Western border of Spain.	
Geography: Climate Categories	Wide range from maritime in the north on the Atlantic coast. Warm continental into the interior of the country toward the border with Spain.	
Geography: Physical Feature	**Bodies of Water:** The Douro River- same as the Duero River in Spain Atlantic Ocean- the western border of Portugal **Mountains:** Very mountainous interior	
Soil: Type and/or Name	**Douro and Porto DOP:** Schist	**Douro and Porto DOP:** Schist and Granite
Grape Growing		**Douro and Porto DOP:** Terraces on the mountainsides
Winemaking	**Vinho Verde DOP:** Low alcohol, slight effervescence. **Porto DOP and Madeira DOP**: Fortified wines	
Wine: White Grape Variety Names	**Vinho Verde:** Alvarinho **Madeira:** Sercial, Verdelho, Bual, Malmsey	
Wine: Red Grape Variety Names	**Douro DOP and Porto DOP:** Touriga Nacional	**Madeira:** Tinta Negra
Wine Law /Appellations: DOPs	**Vinho Verde DOP** **Douro DOP** **Porto DOP** **Madeira DOP**	**Douro DOP subregions:** Cima Corgo, Baixo Corgo, Douro Superior **Dão DOP** **Alentejo DOP** **Bairrada DOP** **Alentejo DOP**
Label Terms		**Single Quinta:** Small producers
General Terms		**Lagares:** Stone fermenters
Style	**Vinho Verde DOP:** Low alcohol, slight effervescence. **Douro DOP:** Bold, dry red wines **Porto DOP:** Fortified, sweet red wine **Madeira DOP**: Fortified, dry, medium dry, and sweet white wines	
Classification		
Producer/Proprietary Brand		
Vintage		
History & Lore		
Service of Beverage		
Food and Beverage Pairing		
Business of the Sommelier		